Some people picture an apple and see an apple. Some see nothing at all, and only discover in adulthood that 'picture it in your mind' was never a figure of speech. Whether this belongs under the neurodivergent umbrella is genuinely debated. Many people who have it identify as neurodivergent; some prefer not to. Both are reasonable, and nobody gets to decide it for you.

In plain words

Aphantasia is the absence of voluntary visual imagery — no mental pictures. Around one to four percent of people have it. The opposite, hyperphantasia, means imagery as vivid as real seeing. Neither is a disorder; both are variations. Many people with aphantasia have excellent memory and imagination, just not in pictures.

What it can feel like from the inside

- Realising in your thirties that everyone else was being literal.
- Remembering facts about a face perfectly without being able to see it.
- Guided meditation being completely useless.
- Reading a novel and building the world in concepts rather than images.
- Being unable to conjure a lost person's face, which can hurt a great deal.

What people often get wrong

THE ASSUMPTION	WHAT'S ACTUALLY GOING ON
"You must have a bad memory."	Memory is often fine. It's stored as facts and relationships rather than pictures.
"You have no imagination."	Plenty of aphantasic people are artists, writers and designers. Imagination isn't only visual.
"You just aren't trying."	There's no effort that produces the picture. It isn't a skill being neglected.
"It's a disorder."	It's a variation. Most people who have it are perfectly fine and often unaware.
"Then you don't dream."	Many do dream in images. Voluntary imagery is the part that's absent.

What often comes with it

NOT COMPENSATION PRIZES — GENUINE, USEFUL THINGS

Thinking in concepts and structure rather than pictures.

Often less troubled by intrusive visual memories.

Strong verbal and logical reasoning.

Precise, factual recall.

A very unusual perspective in creative work.

What actually helps

- ☐ Describe things in words, not 'picture it'
- ☐ Skip visualisation exercises
- ☐ Use lists rather than mental walkthroughs
- ☐ Give diagrams and written detail
- ☐ Don't quiz them on what they can see
- ☐ Take their word for it

If someone tells you this is them

HELPFUL

“That's fascinating — how do you do it instead?”

“I'll write it down.”

“Makes sense.”

LESS HELPFUL

“Try harder, you'll see it.”

“That's so sad.”

“So what happens when you read?” *for the twentieth time*

Not a missing picture. A different filing system entirely.

A friendly explainer written for the community — not a diagnostic tool and not medical advice. If you want an assessment, your GP is the place to start. Nobody experiences this identically, so take what fits and leave the rest.

Free to share — print it, forward it, hand it to anyone who needs it. More free guides, one per neurotype, at froglogic.co.uk